IT

was the afternoon of December 4, and the Kempegowda International Airport in Bengaluru had lost all sense of order. The departure boards blinked, then froze. Airline counters stood deserted, as people wandered around dazed and confused. Hundreds of bags lay scattered across the terminal, unattended and unclaimed. It would have been an unsettling sight in any airport, let alone one of India's busiest. Forty-two-year-old animation designer Rituparna Sarkar stood amid the chaos, clutching a ticket she had booked weeks earlier. She was flying to Mumbai for an international animation festival she had organised herself, hoping to arrive a day early. Instead, she watched the airport dissolve into mayhem. "It was worse than a railway station," she says. "Luggage from every possible flight was just lying there. Nobody knew whose it was. Nobody was guarding anything." Airline staff offered no answers. Sarkar remained stranded for 14 hours. She never boarded her flight.

Two days earlier in Bhubaneswar, Sangama Das and Medha Ksheerasagar, both software engineers in their 20s, sat at the airport watching the clock count down to their wedding reception that night in Hubballi, Karnataka. Their IndiGo flight had been put on "delay" since morning till late at night, as relatives and some 700 guests waited in anticipation at the reception venue. Eventually, the airline announced their flight had been cancelled. The couple then found themselves attending their own reception remotely, via video conference.

In the Northeast, Manjuri Palit, a school teacher in her 50s, was stranded at the Guwahati airport on December 5 with the embalmed remains of her husband stored in the cargo hold. She was taking him to Kolkata for burial. All the paperwork, from hospital clearances to permissions from local authorities, had been painstakingly prepared. But the morning flight refused to take off. Embalming lasts only 48 hours. Time was running out.

Sarkar, Das, Ksheersagar and Palit, all had chosen to fly what was till recently perceived as India's most trusted airline. After all, IndiGo had turned punctuality into a promise and then into a brand big enough to be billed "India's favourite". It had also become India's largest airline, cornering over 60 per cent market share for domestic flights. Before crisis struck, it operated more than 400 aircraft, ran roughly 2,300 flights a day, flying to over 90 domestic and 45 international destinations, carrying an average of half a million passengers daily. On-time performance was not a metric for IndiGo; it was the product itself. For nearly two decades, it sold Indians something rare in domestic aviation: predictability, efficiency and reasonable fares. The airline even exhibited a sense of humour, its '6E' flight identifier an apt marker of its uber-cool attitude.

In the first week of December, though, that brand image took a battering. All hell broke loose between December 4 and 6 when an

WHY INDIGO W

HOW INDIGO'S STAFFING GAMBLE BACKFIRED

STRICTER PILOT DUTY RULES

- The Director General of Civil Aviation (DGCA) rolls out **22 new Flight Duty Time Limitations** (FDTL) for pilots, to be implemented in two phases: **15** from Jul. 1, **7** from Nov. 1
- **Nov. 1** rules see weekly rest for pilots **go up from 36 to 48 consecutive hrs**; night landings **capped at 2 per week** from 6 before

INDIGO'S FOOT DRAGGING

- Though DGCA **notified new FDTL standards in Jan. 2024**, IndiGo fails to induct more pilots
- The **airline's pilot strength declines** inexplicably from

5,463 in March

▼

5,085 in December

